

MERZIYAH POONAWALA, MBA

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Senior Product Manager with 10+ years of B2B and B2C experience delivering 0->1 products across various industries: healthcare, fintech, and marketplaces. Successful track record advising business leaders on product strategy, delivering lean roadmaps, and conducting user research at early-stage and enterprise clients. Delivered 6 MVPs securing \$85M in startup funding. With strong technical background, skilled at aligning teams, navigating tradeoffs, and bringing clarity to ambiguity, delivering in tight timelines at companies like Walmart, Dick's Sporting Goods, and NY Public Radio

Career Highlights:

- Secured \$85M in funding through shipping lean MVPs within time and budget constraints
- Led discovery workshops for Walmart's \$140M AI voice initiative, shaping early product strategy and aligning teams on key user needs
- Mentored 10+ product teams in agile execution, user research, and roadmap strategy to refine product experiences and improve team velocity

SELECTED EXPERIENCE

Senior Product Manager

12/2016 - 09/2024

Def Method, New York, NY (Software Consultancy)

- Provided strategic leadership to startups and Fortune 500 companies on product vision, roadmaps, and execution
- Led cross-functional teams through product development phases from discovery to launch
- Owned the end-to-end product lifecycle, balancing feature delivery, scalability challenges, and technical debt through informed trade-off decisions.
- Conducted market and competitor research, and user interviews to break into new industries
- Developed integration strategies between web and CRM to enable a personalized omni-channel experience at NY Public Radio

Key Achievements:

- Launched 6+ MVPs, within 3-6 month timeframes for apps with a TAM of \$12M-\$600M/year
- Achieved 60% trial period conversion introducing a subscription paywall for Elias Sports Bureau's consumer app, through a keen focus on product messaging
- 2x-ed revenue per paid user by strategically targeting high value segments through deep market and user insights for marketplace app

Product Manager, Core Product

01/2013 - 12/2016

NovoPath, Princeton, NJ

- Owned product lifecycle for a \$25M/year healthcare software suite, working with global development team, streamlining user interactions
- Partnered with vendors on EMR/EHR integration initiatives, enabling seamless record transfer across medical systems
- Collaborated with sales as the product expert, conducting on-site product demos and providing technical knowledge on the product's capabilities
- Conducting on-site user research and workflow analysis, identifying key pain points, and streamlining interdepartmental communication.

- Owned product launch, stakeholder training, and provided on-site support during product go-live, ensuring seamless adoption and high customer satisfaction.

Key Achievements:

- Unlocked \$500M market opportunity by leading user research, product strategy and design for a new medical testing module
- Launched 30+ HL7-compliant EMR solutions by spearheading vendor integrations and translating API specifications into requirements
- Improved customer satisfaction to 95% by revamping release management, increasing transparency and reducing post-release deployment issues
- Drove \$3M revenue increase through partnership with sales and implementation teams

OTHER PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Project Manager, NovoPath, Princeton, NJ

01/2009 - 12/2012

Partnered with pathology lab administrators and pathologists to audit lab workflows, define requirements and implement NovoPath software across departments

- Orchestrated software conversion across hospital and labs for projects ranging from \$500K to \$2M/yr

Software Developer, NovoPath, Princeton, NJ

11/2004 - 12/2008

Built core product features in .NET, Python and SQL

- Defined and executed on technical requirements for Cytopathology module generating over \$1MM in annual revenue.
- Developed an internal CRM tool to track customer-specific features, improving deployment and QA outcomes by 30%.

EDUCATION

Master of Business Administration (MBA) in Management and Business Strategy, Rutgers, Business School • New Brunswick, NJ

Bachelor of Arts in Computer Science, Rice University • Houston, TX

RECENT CERTIFICATIONS

AI Agents Course, Fundamentals of AI (Hugging Face)

Prompt Engineering for ChatGPT (Coursera)

Generative AI for Professionals (AI Mindset)

SKILLS

Product Management: Cross-functional leadership, Product Vision & Strategy, Strategic Roadmaps, Communication, Stakeholder Management, Agile Methodologies, B2C/B2B, User Research & Testing, Customer Journey Mapping, Data Analysis, Success Metrics, Product Lifecycle Management, Prototyping, Customer Experience & Support

Technologies/Tools:

SQL, Python, API Integration, Analytics (Looker, Google Analytics), Project Management (Jira, Miro, Figma), Replit